

Reflections on "Memories of the Future"

I recently visited the "Memories of the Future" exhibition at the *New Museum* in Manhattan. The exhibition explores how we imagine the future through the lens of our past and present experiences. Walking through the galleries, I noticed that while the art is contemporary and experimental, it relies heavily on the fundamental design principles we have discussed in class, such as **Hierarchy, Rhythm, and Line**. For this reflection, I have chosen to analyze three specific pieces that demonstrate these concepts.

Piece 1: "The Cosmic Sphere"

The first piece that caught my attention was a large-scale painting featuring a vibrant blue circle in the center with colorful lines exploding outward. This work is a perfect study of **Emphasis** and **Rhythm**.



The blue circle acts as the **primary focal point** due to its central placement and large **scale**. Our eyes start at the center and move outward along the thin, dripping lines. These lines create a powerful sense of **Rhythm**; they look like musical notes or energy waves moving across the canvas. The **Color Scheme** is highly **saturated**, using primary colors like red, yellow, and blue to create high **contrast** against the white background. This high level of visual activity represents a "future" that is busy, energetic, and interconnected.

Piece 2: "The Mechanical Portrait"

The second piece I analyzed was a black-and-white collage of a human head constructed from mechanical and architectural parts. This piece relates directly to our discussions on **Figure-Ground relationships and Texture**.



The artist uses **Tonal Contrast** (black ink on white paper) to create a sharp "figure" that pops forward from the "ground." By building a face out of gears and buildings, the artist creates a complex **Visual Texture**. The **Hierarchy** here is clever: we first see the human face (the organic

shape), and then we notice the mechanical details (the geometric shapes). This mix of organic and geometric forms perfectly illustrates the theme of humans merging with technology in the future.

Piece 3: “The Surreal Portrait”

The third piece features a dark, tall figure standing behind a white table with small ballet dancers in the background. This painting is an excellent example of **Balance and Proportional Scale**.



The artist uses **Symmetrical Balance** by placing the main subject in the center. However, the most interesting part is the **Proportion**. The small scale of the ballet dancers compared to the large scale of the dark figure creates a feeling of mystery and depth. The **Color Palette** is very **muted** and neutral, which creates a quiet, serious **tone**. The sharp horizontal line of the table and the vertical line of the figure create a stable **grid-like structure** that keeps the composition from feeling messy.

In conclusion, attending "Memories of the Future" helped me see that design principles are not just for apps or posters; they are the "language" that artists use to tell stories. Whether it is the **rhythmic lines** of a cosmic painting or the **tonal contrast** of a mechanical collage, these elements help the viewer understand complex ideas about what is coming next. This visit was a great way to see the real-world application of the concepts we are learning in MEDPL 150.